

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
The Language of Silence*

February 16th, 2025



*Mauna Kea, Volcano in Hawaii
Photo by Sean Goebel*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Meditation on *Adoro Te Devote* (Gregorian Chant)
Fugues in D minor and D Major (Johann Sebastian Bach)

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Indian Springs School Chamber Choir, Dr. Lee Wright, Director

Locus Iste (Anton Brucker)
Evocation (Hey-Young Cho)
Measure Me, Sky (Jonathan R. Reid)

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Hymn Improvisation

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Janette Tovar

Come, all who are weary
from the crowd and bustle of the day:
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Come, all who delight
in the abundance of everyday treasures:
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Come, all who are made restless
by acquiescence to injustice.
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Come, all who seek
glimpses of quiet transcendence:
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Come, all whose spirits are frayed
from the pull of unforeseen difficulties:
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Come, all with open hearts,
ready to listen for the mystery:
God's steadfast love awaits us.

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering.** *Holy, Wondrous Mystery, Birthing All Creation*

NICAEA

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
Every day your songs arise from nature's harmony.
Holy, wondrous mystery, breath of our formation,
Source of all life throughout infinity.

Holy wondrous mystery, one in all things dwelling,
Everywhere in everyone you bring divinity.
Holy, sacred presence, loving and compelling,
Living and moving through eternity.

Holy wondrous mystery, darkness magnifies you,
In the darkened depths of soil you root and sprout and thrive
Holy, spacious darkness, moon and sun shine through you.
Stars on your canvas bring the skies to life.

Holy wondrous mystery, birthing all creation,
All your works resound in praise from earth and sky and sea.
Holy wondrous mystery, glorious revelation,
Song of all life throughout infinity.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Eternal God, every day
we receive fragments of holiness,
glimpses of eternity,
brief moments of insight.
Often, in our ever busy lives,
we fail to perceive and feel this holiness
which surrounds us, wherever we are.

This morning, we ask for help,
because we long to gather these moments
for the precious gifts they are.
And then, renewed by their grace,
move boldly into the silent unknown.

We pray that with the dawn of each new day,
we will be open to being transformed
and illuminated by the light we have been given,
so that we will become more fully human,
more fully your creation.

*We pray this in the memory of the all those
who, throughout time eternal,
have given their light,
which we now hold and share.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

***Introit**

“Sing Gloria”
Cathedral Choir and Indian Springs School Choirs

WILLIAM BILLINGS

***The Lord’s Prayer**

Janette Tovar

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

In this Epiphany season, in the midst of all that is around us,
we seek a sacred time and space
where we might *learn* peace,
because in these days we are learning that peace is more
than the absence of discordance.

Peace is the intent with which to listen to diverse points of view;
it is the intentional speaking of all voices,
one at a time;
It is the tension within silence that welcomes all thoughts.
So, let us seek not just harmony; rather, let us learn peace.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Baptismal Song

We Are

YSAYE M. BARNWELL

Baptism of Emilia LaRue Trainor

Rev. Lehman

Daughter of Lisa and Andrew Trainor

Musical Gift

Song of Dedication

Mark Donner, *Soloist*

REBECCA M. WARNOCK

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Janette Tovar

from the Gospel of Mark & the Psalms

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One,
the world we live in is filled with
challenges, crises, pain, and disappointment.
We know these things intimately
because we have felt them, experienced them,
and railed against them.
Help us, O God, to not grow weary,
but instead to rise as those who would understand not only
what the world is,
but what we can make it be.
Guided by your grace and mercy,
we become your hands, your heart, and your voice,
in making it so in this, our time and place.

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us!

Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

DANIEL KESSNER & LIONELLE HAMANAKA

"The Birds Were Singing When We Came" from *The Camp*

Tiffany Ho, *Soloist*

Sermon

The Language of Silence

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Exultate Deo"

ALESSANDRO SCARLATTI

Indian Springs School Chamber Choir and Laude, Dr. Lee Wright, *Conductor*

*"Sing joyfully to God, our strength; sing loud unto the God of our ancestors!
Take the song, bring forth the timbrel, the pleasant harp, and the viol.
Blow the trumpet in the new moon, at the time appointed for our feast day."*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Janette Tovar

Holy One,
when given pause to truly see this world,
we stand in awe of its beauty.
When truly hearing words
that share us with another's heart,
we stand amazed at the diversity of humanity.
When time allows
and our thoughts travel deep into our own souls,
a wordless place of images and dreams,
we stand within Holiness and we are blessed.

With hope, we greeted this time together
as one in which all this might happen,
and, with blessing, make us feel at home.

*So now, Holy One,
with these gifts we thank you
for these blessed and beautiful moments.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

As we leave this place,
let us remember who we are...

*We are the people who heal each other,
who grow strong together,
who know what it means
to live in community,
moving towards a common dream
for a world filled with inclusiveness,
compassion, and generosity,
found in the power of the love of God,
the company of Jesus,
and the leading of the Holy Spirit.*

Go now in peace,
as those who share a common way,
and may you find others
to share this path with you.
May the hospitality you share
return to you through the love of God
both this day, and forever more.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“Hope”

YSAYE M. BARNWELL

Cathedral Choir and Indian Springs School Choirs

*Hymn for the Journey

Go and Find the Quiet Center

BEACH SPRING

Go and find the quiet center in the crowded life we lead,
Find the room for hope to enter, find the frame where we are freed:
Clear the chaos and the clutter, clear our eyes, that we can see
All the things that really matter, be at peace, and simply be.

Silence is a friend who claims us, cools the heat and slows the pace,
God it is who speaks and names us, knows our being, touches base,
Making space within our thinking, lifting shades to show the sun,
Raising courage when we're shrinking, finding scope for faith begun.

In the Spirit let us travel, open to each other's pain,
Let our loves and fears unravel, celebrate the space we gain:
There's a place for deepest dreaming, there's a time for heart to care,
In the Spirit's lively scheming there is always room to spare!

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Fugue in D minor - Reprise (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Inside The Music

“We have the privilege of singing two pieces by Dr. Ysaye Barnwell today. Her “We Are” has become our baptismal celebration song, and for our choral response we will sing “Hope.” Dr. Barnwell is a medical doctor who spent decades of her life singing with Sweet Honey In the Rock, and continues to teach group singing as one expression of her social activism. In visiting with her music for today's service, I find that the language of resistance has interesting similarities to the daily practice of a religious cloister. The patient practice of monkhood inspires the human body into a place of focus and change. So does the patient practice of resistance. Both require a level of commitment that feels beyond our comprehension. Yet, Barnwell reminds us that if we don't nurture this daily practice, our very survival is at risk. “If we want hope to survive in this world today,” she writes, “then every day we've got to: pray on, work on, move on, march on, sing on.” We have the pleasure of being joined by the Indian Springs Choir from Birmingham, Alabama. Their director, Dr. Lee Wright, is a long-time friend and colleague. They represent a progressive enclave in Alabama, and are excited to be amongst us as we all consider the new world we live in. The other choral songs we sing this week come from their concert program that they will present on Sunday evening (2/16 5:00pm in Shatto), and to which you are

invited. I chose songs of praise to surround the focus on silence for specific reasons. If you have listened to any professional advice giver, you will hear them say over and over again that life is practice. This statement is more than just motivational speech, it is supported by neuroscience, DNA research, and biology. Who we are and who we want to be are dependent entirely on the daily practice of our lives. With American colonial composer William Billings' "Sing Gloria," and early Baroque Italian composer Alessandro Scarlatti's "Exultate Deo," I wanted to remind us of the principal motivation to dedicate ourselves to life practice. The unique expressions of joy and release that they each find through their different musical language reflects that motivation. When we commit ourselves to daily reinforcement of the life we want to lead, the benefits increase exponentially. Praise even feels like a faint recognition of the newness we experience. The songs of celebration we sing today are in recognition of all that we each find through our own practices. They are a release into the hope of being that provides that great motivation to begin, if only for 5 minutes a day. Tiffany is offering us the gift of a special preview from a new opera that she is in called *The Camp*. It opens next weekend, and I hope many of us will get to experience its powerful message. It tells the story of the 120,000 people of Japanese descent who were unjustly incarcerated in American concentration camps during the second world war. For the meditation, Tiffany will sing the aria the mother sings as she is forced to leave her family home. Her memories flow through her senses. The sights, sounds, touches, and tastes of home fill her mind in that pivotal moment of loss. In a larger work focused on the unjust torment that people can wage upon one another, excerpts like this can be easily missed. They remind us that the beauty of humanity resides in our ability to notice and connect with our surroundings and with others. The patient practice of life depends on our awareness. Our ability to treat one another with compassion, to seek hope in the coming days, and to joyfully celebrate this moment flows from the senses that connect us through common humanity to one another." ~ Dr. David Harris